

HTTP Status Codes Reference

Every status class a tester needs — and what to check.

Status codes are the first thing an API tells you about a request. This reference groups them by class, lists the codes you will actually meet, and — crucially — says what to verify as a tester when you see each one.

What the Classes Mean

Class	Meaning	Who to blame
1xx	Informational — request received, continuing	Rarely seen in testing
2xx	Success — the request worked	Nobody; verify the body
3xx	Redirection — further action needed	Usually the client/config
4xx	Client error — the request was wrong	The caller (your request)
5xx	Server error — the server failed	The server/backend

2xx Success

Code	Name	Meaning	Tester note
200	OK	Request succeeded	Confirm the body matches the request; do not stop at the code
201	Created	A new resource was created	Check the Location header and the returned resource
202	Accepted	Accepted for async processing	Verify the job/status endpoint later
204	No Content	Success with no body	Expected for many DELETES; assert there is no body

3xx Redirection

Code	Name	Meaning	Tester note
301	Moved Permanently	Resource has a new permanent URL	Check the Location header; update the client
302	Found	Temporary redirect	Confirm whether your client should follow it

Code	Name	Meaning	Tester note
304	Not Modified	Cached copy is still valid	Test with conditional headers (If-None-Match)
307	Temporary Redirect	Redirect, method preserved	Verify the method is not silently changed

4xx Client Errors

Code	Name	Meaning	Tester note
400	Bad Request	Malformed request or invalid data	Send bad payloads deliberately and expect this
401	Unauthorized	Not authenticated	Test with missing/expired/invalid credentials
403	Forbidden	Authenticated but not allowed	Test with a valid user lacking permission
404	Not Found	Resource does not exist	Request a bad ID; confirm no data leaks in the body
405	Method Not Allowed	Wrong method for the endpoint	Try DELETE on a read-only endpoint
409	Conflict	State conflict, e.g. duplicate	Create the same resource twice
422	Unprocessable Entity	Valid syntax, failed validation	Test business-rule validation, not just format
429	Too Many Requests	Rate limit exceeded	Check for a Retry-After header

5xx Server Errors

Code	Name	Meaning	Tester note
500	Internal Server Error	Unhandled server fault	A bug — log it; the client did nothing wrong
502	Bad Gateway	Bad response from an upstream server	Often infrastructure/proxy; note and escalate
503	Service Unavailable	Server overloaded or down	Check for Retry-After; test graceful degradation
504	Gateway Timeout	Upstream server timed out	Investigate slow dependencies/timeouts

401 vs 403 — the Classic Distinction

These are the two everyone confuses. 401 Unauthorized means "I do not know who you are" — authentication failed or is missing, so logging in (or supplying a valid token) could fix it. 403 Forbidden means "I know who you are, and you still may not do this" — authentication succeeded but you lack the permission, so re-authenticating will not help.

- 401 — no token, expired token, or wrong credentials.
- 403 — valid login, but the resource or action is off-limits to this user.

COMMON MISTAKE

Only asserting that the status is 200. Real APIs return 201, 204, 400, 401, 403, 404, 422 and more — each is correct in its own scenario. Assert the exact status your test expects for that case, and cover the error paths too, not just the happy path.